

# ZIHENG YU

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Department of Economics ♦ The University of Texas at Austin

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## EDUCATION

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**The University of Texas at Austin**

*Aug 2021 - May 2027 (Expected)*

Ph.D. in Economics

- Field courses: Theory, Public Finance

**Duke University**

*Aug 2019 - Dec 2020*

M.A. in Economics

**Wuhan University**

*Sep 2015 - Jun 2019*

Bachelor in Economics

## REFERENCES

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**Thomas Wiseman** (Supervisor)

Professor of Economics

Department of Economics

The University of Texas at Austin

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**David Sibley** (Co-Supervisor)

John Michael Stuart Centennial Professor

Department of Economics

The University of Texas at Austin

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**V. Bhaskar**

Sue Killam Professor

Department of Economics

The University of Texas at Austin

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## RESEARCH

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### Fields and Interests

Microeconomic Theory, Game Theory, Theoretical Industrial Organization, Platform Competition, Market Structure, Bargaining, Information Design

### Working Papers

- “The Case of Apple’s Restrictions on Super Apps: Is the U.S. Department of Justice Right?” (**Job Market Paper**)

**Abstract:** The novel “super app” technology, which emerged in the early 2010s, enables app developers to run a single version of an app on different operating systems. Apple’s alleged practice of restricting super apps in the United States is one of the subjects of a recent antitrust complaint filed by the U.S. Department of Justice (2024). I present a model of a two-sided market with cross-side network effects to investigate two questions: why Apple restricts super apps in the United States but not in Asia; and whether its restrictions may adversely affect market competition and welfare in the United States. I find that a primary reason for Apple’s behavior is the dominant position of its iOS platform on the consumer side of the U.S. smartphone market—iOS does not hold this position in Asia. Furthermore, I show that whether these restrictions harm consumers and developers depends critically on whether consumers view platforms as highly differentiated or close substitutes, the degree to which restrictions on super apps increase consumers’ switching costs and decrease developers’ multi-homing savings, and the number of apps operating on each platform.

- “Cheap Talk with Costly Information Acquisition by the Receiver”

**Abstract:** This paper examines the welfare implications of the receiver’s costly information acquisition in a cheap-talk model. I find that both a reduction in the cost of information acquisition and an increase in the informativeness of the information source can generate welfare gains, regardless of the welfare weights and whether receiver learning crowds out sender communication. Furthermore, a cost reduction improves welfare under broader conditions than an equivalent increase in informativeness.

## Work in Progress

- “Interdependent Bargains with Downstream Competition and Vertical Merger”  
*with David Sibley and Yihang Zhou*

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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### As an Assistant Instructor

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| Semester    | Course   |                        |
|-------------|----------|------------------------|
| Fall 2025   | ECO 329  | Economic Statistics    |
| Summer 2025 | ECO n329 | Economic Statistics-WB |

### As a Teaching Assistant

| Semester    | Course                                                       | Professor                                 |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Fall 2026   | ECO 394K Microeconomics (Master level)                       | Gerald Oettinger                          |
| Spring 2026 | ECO 352K Business Strategy                                   | David Sibley                              |
| Fall 2024   | ECO 353M Empirical Public Economics                          | David Sibley                              |
| Summer 2024 | ECO f320L Macroeconomic Theory-WB                            | Trenton Herriford                         |
| Spring 2024 | ECO 386D Microeconomics II (PhD level)                       | Svetlana Boyarchenko                      |
| Spring 2024 | ECO 354K Introductory Game Theory                            | V. Bhaskar                                |
| Fall 2023   | ECO 420K Microeconomic Theory                                | Gerald Oettinger                          |
| Summer 2023 | ECO s395M 1-Real Analysis (Master level)                     | Kirk Blazek                               |
| Spring 2023 | ECO 386D Microeconomics II (PhD level)                       | Svetlana Boyarchenko                      |
| Fall 2022   | ECO 354K Introductory Game Theory                            | V. Bhaskar                                |
| Spring 2022 | ECO 304K Introduction to Microeconomics                      | G. Dirk Mateer                            |
| Fall 2021   | ECO 304K Intro to Microeconomics-WB                          | Charity-Joy Acchiardo<br>& G. Dirk Mateer |
| Fall 2020   | ECON 464 Competitive Strategy and<br>Industrial Organization | Huseyin Yildirim                          |

### Others

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|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Spring 2025 | Supplemental Instruction Supervisor in Economics<br>at Sanger Learning Center of the University of Texas at Austin |
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### SKILLS

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|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Softwares & Tools | Matlab, Stata, Microsoft Office, L <sup>A</sup> T <sub>E</sub> X                       |
| Language          | English, professional working proficiency<br>Mandarin, native or bilingual proficiency |